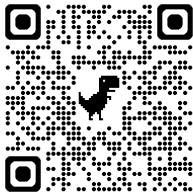


Power Play: Elite Networks and Authoritarian Leadership Challenges

Samuel Morgan Martin

Department of Political Science, University of Toronto

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Introduction

- ▶ Why are some challenge entry dictators more successful at consolidating their regime?
- ▶ Leadership challenges: irregular replacement of an incumbent leader by elites.
- ▶ I develop a network theory of leadership challenges and test the theory using network data and case studies of Nigeria's 1983 and 1985 coups.

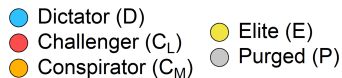
Setup

- ▶ All elites prefer to be an elite rather than be purged; some elites have a strong **unobserved** preference to be the dictator (satisfied vs ambitious types).
- ▶ Elites' decision to lead a challenge is influenced by two considerations: the risk of being purged by the current dictator, and their expected security as the dictator.
- ▶ Expected security depends heavily on the coalition members, because they gain resources and experience by planning and executing successful challenge (Goldring and Matthews 2023).

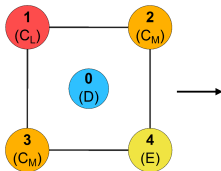
Challenges and purges

- ▶ Elites can only join a challenge if they are connected to the challenge leader.
- ▶ The incumbent is deposed if the challenger mobilizes threshold τ^* of elites.
- ▶ The incumbent can purge elites, but there is a chance that a challenge happens first.

Commitment problems illustrated ($\tau^* = .5$)

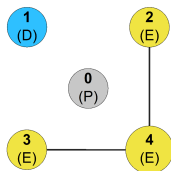


T1: Challenge succeeds

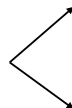


Generic coalition led by Node 1

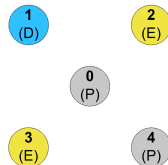
T2: Post-challenge status quo



Node 4 has unique coalition.

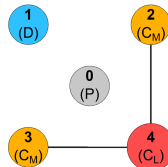


T3: Purge



Purge succeeds; Node 1 is secure as dictator.

T3: No purge

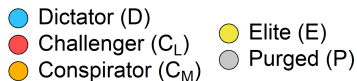


Purge fails; Node 4 deposits Node 1.

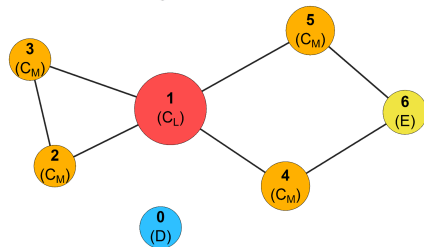
Complementary commitment problems

- ▶ **Post-challenge commitment problem:** coalitions capable of mobilizing against their leader cannot commit leaving their leader in power.
 - ▶ Challengers need a **unique coalition**, a coalition that is unlikely to be mobilized without their participation.
- ▶ **Pre-challenge commitment problem:** elites with a unique coalition cannot commit to not challenging, and dictators cannot commit to not purging them.
- ▶ Elite's network position determines which commitment problem is solved (betweenness centrality).

Post-challenge commitment induces pre-challenge commitment problem ($\tau^* = .5$)

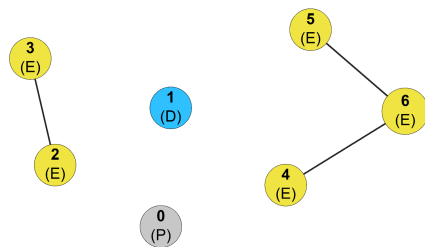


T1: Pre-challenge commitment problem



Unique coalition led by Node 1

T2: Post-challenge status quo



Node 1 is secure as dictator.

Some observable implications

- ▶ High betweenness challengers should be less likely to face subsequent challenges by the coalition that put them into power.
- ▶ High betweenness challengers should implement greater institutional coup proofing reforms such as counterbalancing.
- ▶ Dictators should be more likely to purge high betweenness elites.

Case studies: Nigeria, 1983-1993

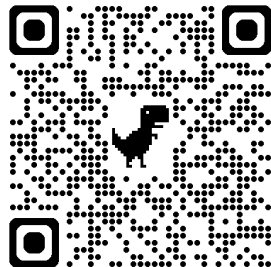
I combine process-tracing with an original network dataset to compare two Nigerian coup episodes (1983, 1985) in a temporal design.

Table: Comparison of Network Metrics and Outcomes: Buhari vs. Babangida

Leader	Betweenness	Outcomes		
		Coup Proofing	Mode of exit	Tenure
Maj.-Gen. Buhari	Low	Low	Removed by own coalition	1.7 years
Maj.-Gen. Babangida	High	High	Voluntary resignation	8 years

Conclusion

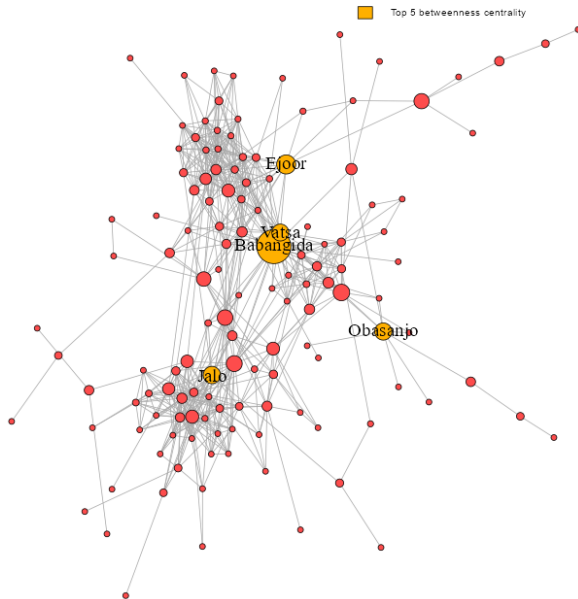
- ▶ I highlight two complementary commitment problems, and show how elites' betweenness determines which commitment problem they face.
- ▶ Case study examines recruitment processes as well as commitment problems in two Nigerian military regimes.
- ▶ Contact me at **sammorgan.martin@mail.utoronto.ca** or scan the QR code to read a working draft. Comments are greatly appreciated!



Network data

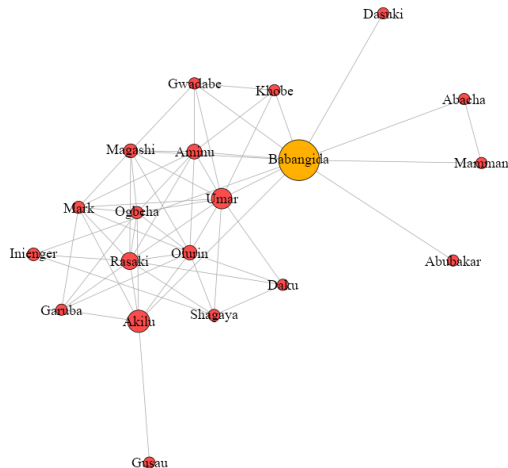
- ▶ Using an open weight language model (Qwen3.5-27b), I extracted actor-org and actor-actor data from a text corpus of 1048 Wikipedia articles.
 - ▶ Text corpus included any article with Wikipedia categories relevant for Nigerian officers.
- ▶ For years of interest, edges were coded if they had a direct relation or overlapped in the same organization in a prior year (binarized, undirected).
- ▶ Connected component for military elites in 1982: 153 actors.

Nigerian military elite network (1982)



Babangida's coup coalition

- ▶ Babangida: high betweenness.
- ▶ No purges of coalition; no challenges from his coalition.
- ▶ A (nearly) unique coalition.



Officers briefed on 1985 coup conspiracy. Membership from Omoigui (n.d.). Edges as of 1984.

Conclusion

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